



Indian Roster

All matches at 8:35 p.m.*

Feb 28: v/s Pakistan

Mar 2: v/s Australia

Mar 4: v/s Spain

Mar 6: v/s England

Mar 8: v/s South Africa

Other Entertainment

Mar 1:

Germany v/s Korea (6:35 p.m.)

Holland v/s Argentina (8:35 p.m.)

Mar 2:

Pakistan v/s Spain (6:35 p.m.)

Mar 4:

England v/s Pakistan (6:35 p.m.)

Mar 5:

Germany v/s Argentina (8:35 p.m.)

Mar 6:

Australia v/s Spain (4:35 p.m.)

Mar 7:

Germany v/s Holland (8:35 p.m.)

Mar 8:

Australia v/s Pakistan (6:35 p.m.)

Mar 9:

Holland v/s Korea (6:35 p.m.)

Semi-finals:

March 11:

Pool A1 v/s Pool B2 (6:05 p.m.)

Pool B1 v/s Pool A2 (8:35 p.m.)

Final:

March 13: 6:05 p.m.

**The event is live on Ten Sports*



WORLD CUP 2006 CHAMPS GERMANY

crats, coaches and even a grumbling generation of old champions.

Indian hockey today is a lonely planet, adrift from the heart of the galaxy and its magnetic, moving centre. It is not hard to understand why.

Can India Win the World Cup? Why Ever Not?

All right, time to sit down, take a deep breath and swallow some bitter tonic. India are in this World Cup due to a lone, red-faced reason—we're hosting it. Twice the FIH's shape shifters have threatened to airlift the event away, twice they have stayed put and so has our presence. In 2006, India failed to win an Asian Games medal for the first time in history. A year later, it failed to qualify for the Beijing Olympics, the first time in six decades.

That was not the beginning of India's slide, that was actually the bottom of the pit. Missing the Olympics has cost them ranking points and sent them into a very different neighbourhood. From being a team that was a top-six regular, they are

now ranked number 12, behind New Zealand and Canada.

Before leaving for the Cup, Australian coach and once technical director for Indian hockey Ric Charlesworth said that home teams tend to do well in big events. Midfielder Arjun Halappa said, "Every team at this World Cup will want to finish as winners... we won't take what's happened to us in these last two months on the field." Sturdy words that convince very few.

Former India midfielder and coach Joachim Carvalho says that expecting India to win the World Cup is "asking for too much. Everyone knows the Indian team does not stand a chance." India's aim, he says, should be to finish in the top

six and trying to get into the Champions Trophy.

It may look like small pickings but forget about those eight Olympic golds or the 1975 World Cup. Not only because the players are sick of hearing about them, but because they belong to museums that feature steam engines and telex machines. Today's hockey is a different sport in a different age. Just accepting that on and off the field will mean doing the one thing Indian hockey has not in a long time—embracing reality.

When Did We Fall So Low?

Was it failing in Doha or missing out on Beijing? Indian Olympian Jude Menezes has no hesitation. "We've been sliding since the 1980s," he says. From the time world hockey changed, but India didn't. "We had a few teams



Photographs by AP PHOTO